

Free As One Exhibit: Black-Led Abolition in the Pennsylvania Abolition Society Papers

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Black Led Abolition in the Pennsylvania Abolition Society Papers; Our New Exhibit Opens on February 6

1838 Black Metropolis is launching an exhibit titled "Free, As One: Black Worldmaking in the Pennsylvania Abolition Society Papers," opening February 6, 2025 at the Historical Society of Pennsylvania. The exhibition challenges conventional narratives about abolition by centering Black leadership and agency in the anti-slavery movement.

Discover the Global Movement for Emancipation

The exhibit counters a persistent historical myth that "White people, motivated by altruistic benevolence, were the primary architects of the movement." Instead, it documents how Black-led efforts for freedom mobilized abolitionist action and drove transformative change.

Grounded in Scholarship: Shifting the Narrative

The exhibit draws on scholarly work by Gerald Horne, Manisha Sinha, Kirsten Sword, and Mary T. Freeman, demonstrating how enslaved people's strategic organization was the driving force behind abolitionist movements. The presentation emphasizes how Black and Brown people "envisioned new futures and created new worlds for themselves" despite extreme oppression, focusing on unity and generational hope.

Exhibit Themes: Illuminating Black-Led Emancipation

The exhibit organizes content into four key themes:

For The Global Movement: Black consciousness connected emancipation efforts across nations, featuring documents like a letter of passage from Toussaint L'Ouverture sending a delegate to an anti-slavery meeting in Philadelphia.

For All Oppressed People: Abolition encompassed liberation for Indigenous, Asian, and other marginalized groups, including cases like Dinah Nevil's, a Lenni Lenape woman whose case inspired the Pennsylvania Abolition Society's formation.

For the Family and Community: Stories like Polidore's relentless fight to free his wife Rose demonstrate deeply human motivations behind Black-led abolitionist efforts, showing how family bonds drove the movement.

For the Future: The fight was future-focused, ensuring generational stability. Amy Reckless self-emancipated in 1825 and immediately sought legal support from the PAS, strategically documenting abuse she suffered. She later opened a shelter for Black women in 1843 with Hetty Burr and became a key leadership figure in the Female Anti-Slavery Society and Female Vigilance Committee.

Why Attend?

The exhibit offers primary source documents that reshape understanding of abolition as a "global, Black-led movement" and places "Black agency at the forefront."

Exhibit Details

Dates: Thursday, February 6 - Friday, May 23

Hours:

- Tuesday: 10:00 a.m. - 4:00 p.m.
- Wednesday: 1:00 p.m. - 7:00 p.m.
- Thursday: 10:00 a.m. - 4:00 p.m.
- Friday: 10:00 a.m. - 4:00 p.m.

Cost: Free

Location: Historical Society of Pennsylvania, 1300 Locust Street, Philadelphia, PA 19107

Images

- Exhibition opening image — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_eebc6b6db3aa4a7186cb168ad0e9a0fd~mv2.jpg
- Unidentified exhibition graphic — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_deac369872384fbfaff881776734df7d~mv2.jpg
- Letter of Passage from Toussaint L'Overture — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_aedc980c4874429ea21771a01107a1e4~mv2.jpg
- AI Reimagining of Dinah Nevil and her children — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fa66fed30e00443ab1f27fe3ba0cde48~mv2.png
- Polidore's status document — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_b892a4d296e34654b5a7be1d6e51abd1~mv2.jpg
- Case of Amy Reckless — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_86c918b3c554497ba4bc9a668af46b1e~mv2.jpg

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